



Active Frames

BlackBerry OS10's “Active Frames” live on – as an open-source, from-scratch build for any Android phone. This guide shows what the tiles do and how to set them up.

Version 0.21 · GNU GPLv3 · no BlackBerry code, only open Android interfaces

Source & APK: github.com/8818freak/ActiveFrames

All screenshots are from real use – personal content has been redacted.

1 What is Active Frames?

On the BlackBerry OS10 home screen, “Active Frames” showed your recently used apps as living tiles: top-left the most recently opened, each with the content of its latest notification, a red star for anything new. **Active Frames** rebuilds this from scratch – all its own code, not a single line from any BlackBerry app, only public, documented Android interfaces (usage stats, notification access, optionally the accessibility service).

Free, open source (GNU GPLv3), no ads, no analytics, no internet permission. Runs on any Android device from version 10 – no BlackBerry device needed.

2 Setup

On first launch the app walks you through three grants. Each opens its own system screen; these are not ordinary runtime dialogs.

1. Usage access (for the order)

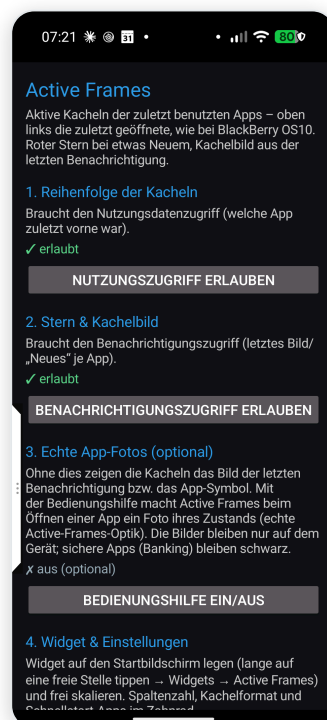
Tells the app which app was in front most recently – that produces the BlackBerry order (top-left = most recently used).

2. Notification access (for star & tile image)

Provides each app's latest image (chat photo, cover, large icon) and whether there is something new (red star).

3. Accessibility (optional, real app photos)

Only when enabled: Active Frames takes a photo of an app's state when you open it (true Active-Frames look). Images stay on the device only. Apps that block screenshots (banking, BBMe) show their logo instead of a black tile.



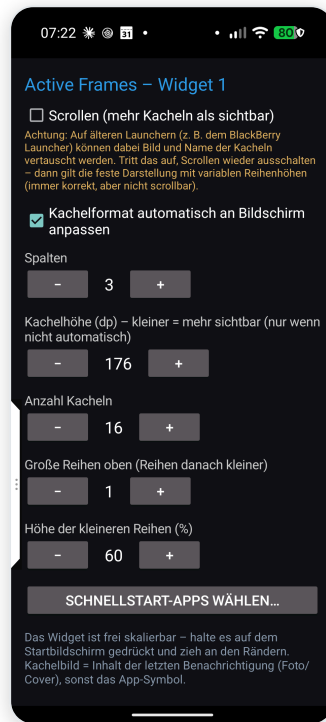
Home screen with the three grants

3 Placing the widget

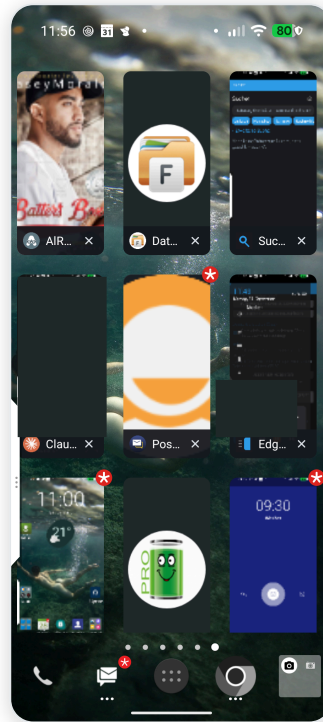
Long-press the home screen → *Widgets* → drag *Active Frames* onto a free spot and resize it freely by its edges. The gear icon on the tile opens the settings.

4 Settings

- **Columns:** e.g. 2 like OS10 on smaller devices, 4 like on the Passport.
- **Automatic tile format:** matches tile height to the screen's aspect ratio (rectangular like the screen, not always square). Or set the height manually.
- **Tile count** and **large rows on top** (top rows large, then smaller – like OS10).
- **Scrolling (more tiles than fit):** see the note below.
- **Quick-launch apps:** pinned apps that always stay first.



Widget 1 settings



Tiles on the home screen

5 The tiles

- **Order:** top-left is the most recently used app, then the one before, and so on.
- **Red star:** appears for anything new and clears on launch.
- **Tile image:** content of the latest notification; if there is none, the app logo is shown tile-sized (centred, undistorted).
- **Close (X):** hides a tile; it reappears as soon as the app is used again or sends something new.

Note on scrolling

Scrolling mode shows more tiles than fit. It uses an Android collection; on most launchers this works. On some older ones (e.g. the BlackBerry Launcher) tile image and name could previously swap – that is fixed by sending small per-tile bitmaps directly (the same approach BlackBerry's own Hub widget uses). If it still glitches on an unusual launcher: turn scrolling off (the fixed layout is always correct) or use “Widget 2” in EdgeTab.

Refresh in scrolling mode (jumping on close)

When you close a tile in scrolling mode, the widget has to update. How it does so is controlled by two switches under the scrolling switch in the settings – giving three behaviours:

- **Full (both switches off – default):** Always reliable, but the launcher briefly rebuilds the collection on refresh – tile images may “jump” for a moment when closing. That is the limit of some launchers (esp. the BlackBerry Launcher).
- **Gentle refresh (on):** Updates the tiles without rebuilding the collection – no jump on **modern launchers**. Some launchers (BlackBerry) accept it only unreliably; then, over time, tiles can no longer be closed.
- **Hybrid (gentle on + “Full refresh on actions” on):** Scrolling, incoming notifications and image sharpening stay smooth; **opening and closing** take the reliable full path. That way the BlackBerry Launcher picks up the **new tile order** when you open something (in pure gentle mode it stayed put) and wakes the collection back up so gentle refresh works again afterwards. Opening is invisible (the opened app covers the home screen); only closing jumps briefly. Recommended for the **BlackBerry Launcher**.

In short: on modern launchers enable “Gentle refresh” (smooth and reliable). On the BlackBerry Launcher also enable “Full refresh on actions” – then the order is correct after opening too. Or use the native “Widget 2” card in EdgeTab for a consistently smooth, scrollable overview.

6 Widget 2 in EdgeTab

In the **EdgeTab** app you can add a native “Active Frames” card. It reads order, stars and images from Active Frames over a secured content channel – EdgeTab needs no extra permissions of its own. Because EdgeTab draws the tiles itself, that card scrolls reliably, even on older launchers.

7 Backup & restore

On the app's home screen you can back up and restore all settings (columns, format, count, rows, quick-launch apps) as a file – via the system file dialog, without storage permission. Tile images and stars are not saved; they rebuild themselves.

8 Limitations & privacy

True live per-app snapshots like BlackBerry's original are not available to a non-system app on Android – only the system launcher may read task snapshots, and no launcher exposes them to other apps. The notification image, or (optionally) the accessibility photo, is the closest feasible substitute. All images stay on the device only; the app has no internet permission.